Lesson 6

Backsliding

"So, if you think you are standing firm,
be careful you don't fall!"
(1 Corinthians 10:12)

Backslide: to regress; to slip backwards or revert
to a previous, worse state

Has your faith become dull and lacking in enthusiasm? Have you drifted out of the habit of reading the Bible, praying, attending church, helping others, and witnessing to those who do not know Christ? Are you lazy, undisciplined, and lacking in self-control? Are you trapped in life-dominating sins? Is your conscience seared to the point that you no longer experience godly sorrow when you sin?

"Backsliding" is a recurring theme throughout the Bible—God's people falling away from their faith and belief in him and falling back into sin. The process can be slow and gradual, or sudden; unfortunately, the result is always the same. We fall away from our close personal relationship with God and fall into spiritual dullness or outright sin and disobedience.

God deplores our backsliding and desires that we return to our former relationship with Him. He personally appeals to us to return, and He disciplines those who do not.

If you feel that you are starting to backslide, stay alert and remain self-controlled. If you feel you are already in a state of spiritual dullness, or if you feel trapped in sinful behavior, turn your heart back to God and His love. He is waiting for you with open arms.

Please read on…

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Synopsis

Most people are "on fire" for the Lord when they first become Christians—when they are "born again." However, slowly over time, their enthusiasm can begin to grow cold as they live out their lives in a fallen and sin-filled world.

Sometimes the process of backsliding is largely a "passive" process, whereby the believer gradually drifts away from a Spirit-filled relationship with God. The Bible uses a variety of terms to describe this process:

- Forgetting God[1]
- Heart Turning Away From God[2,3]
- Forsaking Your First Love[4]
- Turning Away From the Gospel[5]

If you ever forget the LORD your God and follow other gods and worship and bow down to them, I testify against you today that you will surely be destroyed.
(Deuteronomy 8:19)[1]

The LORD became angry with Solomon because his heart had turned away from the LORD, the God of Israel, who had appeared to him twice. Although he had forbidden Solomon to follow other gods, Solomon did not keep the LORD'S command.
(1 Kings 11:9-10)[2]

This is what the LORD says: "Cursed is the one who trusts in man, who depends on flesh for his strength and whose heart turns away form the LORD.
(Jeremiah 17:5)[3]

Yet I hold this against you: You have forsaken your first love. Remember the height from which you have fallen! Repent, and do the things you did at first.
(Revelation 2:4-5)[4]

I am astonished that you are so quickly deserting the one who called you by the grace of Christ and are turning to a different gospel—which is really no gospel at all. Evidently some people are throwing you into confusion and are trying to pervert the gospel of Christ. **(Galatians 1:6-7)[5]**

- Wandering From The Faith[6,7]
- Becoming Lazy[8]
- Being Complacent[9]
- Being Lukewarm[10]

Other scriptures suggest that backsliding can take the form of a more conscious and "active" role in the decision to turn to evil and disobey God. The end product of this decision can be slavery to sin.

- Turning To Follow Satan[11]
- Becoming Slaves To Sin[12]
- Being Taken Captive By Satan[13]
- Turning to Evil[14]

They have left the straight way and wandered off to follow the way of Balaam son of Boer, who loved the wages of wickedness.
(2 Peter 2:15)[6]

Some people, eager for money, have wandered from the faith and pierced themselves with many griefs.
(1 Timothy 6:10)[7]

God is not unjust; he will not forget your work and the love you have shown him as you have helped his people and continue to help them. We want each of you to show this same diligence to the very end, in order to make your hope sure. We do not want you to become lazy, but to imitate those who through faith and patience inherit what has been promised.
(Hebrews 6:10-12)[8]

The complacency of fools will destroy them.
(Proverbs 1:32)[9]

So, because you are lukewarm—neither hot nor cold—I am about to spit you out of my mouth.
(Revelation 3:16)[10]

Some have in fact already turned away to follow Satan.
(1 Timothy 5:15)[11]

They promise them freedom, while they themselves are slaves of depravity—for a man is a slave to whatever has mastered him.
(2 Peter 2:19)[12]

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The Bible also describes the condition of "backsliding" metaphorically, as:

- Salt Losing Its Saltiness[15]
- Being Asleep[16]
- Serving Two Masters[17]
- Grass Without Water[18]
- Seed Sown Among Thorns[19]

Those who oppose him he must gently instruct, in the hope that God will grant them repentance leading them to a knowledge of the truth, and that they will come to their senses and escape from the trap of the devil, who has taken them captive to do his will.
(2 Timothy 2:25-26)[13]

Do good, O LORD, to those who are good, to those who are upright in heart. But those who turn to crooked ways the LORD will banish with the evildoers.
(Psalm 125:4-5)[14]

You are the salt of the earth. But if the salt loses its saltiness, how can it be made salty again? It is no longer good for anything, except to be thrown out and trampled by men.
(Matthew 5:13)[15]

So then, let us not be like others, who are asleep, but let us be alert and self-controlled.
(1 Thessalonians 5:6)[16]

No servant can serve two masters. Either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve both God and Money.
(Luke 16:13)[17]

Can papyrus grow tall where there is no marsh? Can reeds thrive without water? While still growing and uncut, they wither more quickly than grass. Such is the destiny of all who forget God; so perishes the hope of the godless.
(Job 8:11-13)[18]

Still others, like seed sown among thorns, hear the word; but the worries of this life, the deceitfulness of wealth and the desires for other things come in and choke the word, making it unfruitful.
(Mark 4:18-19)[19]

- A Dead Branch[20]
- Building A House Without a Firm Foundation[21]
- Being Taken Captive Through Hollow and Deceptive Philosophy[22]

All Christians backslide temporarily at one point or another in their lives; however, remaining in a state of indifference, or sinful separation from God, can have serious outcomes. As time progresses, our hearts may become hardened through backsliding[23] and our consciences may become "seared."[24]

That's one reason why God recommends that we examine ourselves to see if we are living fully in the faith.[25] We can undertake this

If anyone does not remain in me, he is like a branch that is thrown away and withers; such branches are picked up, thrown into the fire and burned.
(John 15:6)[20]

But everyone who hears these words of mine and does not put them into practice is like a foolish man who built his house on sand. The rain came down, the streams rose, and the winds blew and beat against that house, and it fell with a great crash.
(Matthew 7:26-27)[21]

See to it that no one takes you captive through hollow and deceptive philosophy, which depends on human tradition and the basic principles of this world rather than on Christ.
(Colossians 2:8)[22]

You will be ever hearing but never understanding; you will be ever seeing but never perceiving. For this people's heart has become calloused; they hardly hear with their ears, and they have closed their eyes.
(Matthew 13:14-15)[23]

Such teachings come from hypocritical liars, whose consciences have been seared with a hot iron.
(1 Timothy 4:2)[24]

Examine yourselves to see whether you are in the faith; test yourselves. Do you not realize that Christ Jesus is in you—unless, of course, you fail the test.
(2 Corinthians 13:5)[25]

self-evaluation by looking at the fruit that our lives are bearing.[26] Are we reaching others for Christ? Are we helping to change lives? If not, then we are almost certainly backsliding.

In the end, backsliding always has negative and bitter consequences.[27] God wants us to return to Him.[28] He wants us to be alert and self-controlled.[29] He wants us to repent[30] and do the things we did when we first knew Him.[31]

Because God loves us so much, He disciplines His children when they drift away from Him or fall back into sin.[32,33] Everyone who sins is disciplined. If you are not disciplined, then you are not true children of God.[34] No discipline seems pleasant at the time we re-

This is to my Father's glory, that you bear much fruit,
showing yourselves to be my disciples.
(John 15:8)[26]

"Your wickedness will punish you; your backsliding will rebuke you. Consider then and realize how evil and bitter it is for you when you forsake the LORD your God and have no awe of me," declares the Lord, the LORD Almighty.
(Jeremiah 2:19)[27]

"Return, faithless people; I will cure you of backsliding."
"Yes, we will come to you, for you are the LORD our God."
(Jeremiah 3:22)[28]

So then, let us not be like others, who are asleep,
but let us be alert and self-controlled.
(1 Thessalonians 5:6)[29]

He is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish,
but everyone to come to repentance.
(2 Peter 3:9)[30]

Repent, and do the things you did at first.
(Revelation 2:5)[31]

You rebuke and discipline men for their sin.
(Psalm 39:11)[32]

Blessed is the man whom God corrects; so do not despise the discipline of the Almighty. For he wounds, but he also binds up; he injures, but his hands also heal.
(Job 5:17-18)[33]

ceive it, but later on it produces a "harvest of righteousness and and peace" for those who are trained by it.[35] Bottom line, consider yourself blessed if you are being disciplined for your backsliding.[36]

Be prepared![37] Our time on earth is short and Christ will be returning soon. We need to have our lives in order when He comes, for He will come "like a thief in the night—at a time when we do not expect Him.[38,39] We need to wake up from our slumber and turn back to God, for He is coming soon.[40,41]

If you are not disciplined (and everyone undergoes discipline),
then you are illegitimate children and not true sons.
(Hebrews 12:8)[34]

No discipline seems pleasant at the time, but painful. Later
on, however, it produces a harvest of righteousness
and peace for those who have been trained by it.
(Hebrews 12:11)[35]

Blessed is the man you discipline, O LORD,
the man you teach from your law.
(Psalm 94:12)[36]

Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved,
a workman who does not need to be ashamed and
who correctly handles the word of truth.
(2 Timothy 2:15)[37]

The day of the Lord will come
like a thief in the night.
(1 Thessalonians 5:2)[38]

You must be ready, because the Son of Man will come
at an hour when you do not expect him.
(Luke 12:40)[39]

The hour has come for you to wake up from your slumber,
because our salvation is nearer now than
when we first believed.
(Romans 13:11)[40]

Behold, I am coming soon!
(Revelation 22:7)[41]

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God's Guidance

Human beings are weak but God is strong.[42] He stands knocking at the door, and wants us to return to Him.[43] Through the power of God, we have been given everything we need to live a life of godliness,[44] and to escape backsliding and the corruption of the world that is caused by evil desires.[45] The Lord knows how to rescue godly men from trials.[46] Repent! And turn back to God.[47] Come back to your senses and stop sinning.[48]

If you think you are standing firm in your faith, be careful you don't fall.[49] If you don't stand firm in your faith, you won't stand at

Look to the LORD and his strength; seek his face always.
(Psalm 105:4)[42]

Here I am! I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in and eat with him, and he with me.
(Revelation 3:20)[43]

His divine power has given us everything we need for life and godliness through our knowledge of him who called us by his own glory and goodness.
(2 Peter 1:3)[44]

Through these he has given us his very great and precious promises, so that through them you may participate in the divine nature and escape the corruption in the world caused by evil desires.
(2 Peter 1:4)[45]

The Lord knows how to rescue godly men from trials and to hold the unrighteous for the day of judgment.
(2 Peter 2:9)[46]

Let him turn to the LORD, and he will have mercy on him, and to our God, for he will freely pardon.
(Isaiah 55:7)[47]

Come back to your senses as you ought, and stop sinning.
(1 Corinthians 15:34)[48]

So, if you think you are standing firm, be careful you don't fall!
(1 Corinthians 10:12)[49]

all.[50] Let nothing move you; always give yourself fully to the Lord.[51] Hold on to the confidence and enthusiasm you had when you first knew God.[52]

Don't swerve to the left or to the right; keep you feet from evil.[53] Sow righteousness.[54] Keep growing spiritually. Make every effort to add to your faith: goodness; knowledge; self-control; perseverance; godliness; brotherly kindness; and love.[55] Aim for perfection; don't settle for "good enough."[56] God doesn't like lukewarm Christians.[57]

Resist the devil and he will flee from you.[58] Just as Satan tempted

If you do not stand firm in your faith, you will not stand at all.
(Isaiah 7:9)[50]

Therefore, my dear brothers, stand firm. Let nothing move you. Always give yourselves fully to the work of the Lord, because you know that your labor in the Lord is not in vain.
(1 Corinthians 15:58)[51]

We have come to share in Christ if we hold firmly till the end the confidence we had at first.
(Hebrews 3:14)[52]

Do not swerve to the right or the left; keep your foot from evil.
(Proverbs 4:27)[53]

Sow for yourselves righteousness, reap the fruit of unfailing love, and break up your unplowed ground; for it is time to seek the LORD, until he comes and showers righteousness on you.
(Hosea 10:12)[54]

For this very reason, make every effort to add to your faith goodness; and to goodness, knowledge; and to knowledge, self-control; and to self-control, perseverance; and to perseverance, godliness; and to godliness, brotherly kindness; and to brotherly kindness, love. **(2 Peter 1:5-7)**[55]

Aim for perfection. **(2 Corinthians 13:11)**[56]

I know your deeds. You are neither hot nor cold. Because you are lukewarm—neither hot nor cold—I am about to spit you out of my mouth. **(Revelation 3:15-16)**[57]

Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.
(James 4:7)[58]

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Jesus when He was weak,[59] he will tempt us when we have our guard down and are distracted by the world.[60] Pray to God for strength and protection from the evil one.[61] In fact, devote yourself to prayer, being watchful that you do not backslide, and thankful that you know our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ.[62]

Read the Bible on a regular basis, and study the scriptures.[63] Do not neglect God's word.[64] Hide the word of God in your heart, so that you don't slip away from Him and fall into sin.[65]

In the end, make every effort to live holy and godly lives.[66] Conduct yourselves in a manner worthy of the gospel of Christ.[67]

Then Jesus was led by the Spirit into the desert to be tempted by the devil. After fasting forty days and forty nights, he was hungry. The tempter came to him and said, "If you are the Son of God, tell these stones to become bread."
(Matthew 4:1-3)[59]

Watch and pray so that you will not fall into temptation. The spirit is willing, but the body is weak.
(Matthew 26:41)[60]

But the Lord is faithful, and he will strengthen and protect you from the evil one.
(2 Thessalonians 3:3)[61]

Devote yourselves to prayer, being watchful and thankful.
(Colossians 4:2)[62]

When your words came, I ate them; they were my joy and my heart's delight, for I bear your name, O LORD God Almighty.
(Jeremiah 15:16)[63]

I will not neglect your word.
(Psalm 119:16)[64]

I have hidden your word in my heart that I might not sin against you.
(Psalm 119:11)[65]

Since everything will be destroyed in this way, what kind of people ought you to be? You ought to live holy and godly lives as you look forward to the day of God and speed its coming.
(2 Peter 3:11)[66]

Whatever happens, conduct yourselves in a manner worthy of the gospel of Christ. **(Philippians 1:27)[67]**